



Streamlining Business Processes

A process is a series of activities that are linked together to deliver a particular product or service. Mapping your processes will enable you to visualize how efficiently your business is organized and reveal any areas for improvement.

Creating a visual representation

Mapping out the key processes that your business uses will help ensure that your operations run as efficiently as possible—reducing costs and waste. It will also highlight which activities within your key processes that are worth investing in, or even eliminating.

The concept of process mapping originated in manufacturing, where raw materials are transformed from their natural state through a series of steps into the finished product. However, you can use process maps for any type of operation—from a restaurant business receiving a booking, greeting the diner, taking their order, and serving the food, to a gardening business, which involves buying seeds,

growing plants, and selling them to customers.

In each case, the aim is to identify each step and its relationship with others. Creating a map is not complicated and simply involves recognizing each step of the processes within your business and sketching it out in sequence to create a visual representation of all the activities involved.

Understanding value

Once you have created a map, you can examine each step of your process and find ways to streamline it. This will help eliminate wasted time and effort and reduce costs. However, you can also use the map to assess the value of each step.

Using a process map

A business-process map can provide revealing and valuable information. Consider each step or activity your business uses to complete each key process. For example, if your business delivers a service, map out every activity you undertake from start to finish. You can now assess each activity to decide whether it is essential or not. Similarly, you can also identify whether it adds value to your business or not. While essential tasks must be retained, nonessential ones that add value are also worth keeping. Review your processes regularly, as new technology may enable you to simplify them.

